

It took intentionality, focus and a lot of hard work just to get back to zero. But I'll never regret putting in the work to get there. Getting out of debt gave me the freedom to decide where my future dollars would go rather than having to use them to pay for past decisions.

## 2) Fully Funded Emergency Fund

A hallmark of financial advice for those on the standard path is to have an emergency fund of three to six months' living expenses. Having an emergency fund in cash is solid advice for most people, particularly those without other financial means to deal with the inevitable adversity of life. But what does it take to save this amount of money for someone following conventional financial advice?

If you save 10 percent of your income while spending the other 90 percent as commonly advised, you would have only accumulated about one month of living expenses after a full year of saving. It would take about five years just to fund six months of living expenses. It's no wonder many on the standard path become discouraged and wind up saving little to nothing.

Contrast this to someone who Chooses FI. Developing a high savings rate requires you to lower your monthly expenses. This